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UAE LEADERS: FUTURE BEGINS WITH OUR PEOPLE

The UAE's leadership celebrates 54th Eid Al Etihad with people-first vision

ABU DHABI
BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Managing Editor

The UAE's leadership marked the 54th Eid Al Etihad with deeply personal messages that placed people, families, and identity at the heart of the nation's future.

In statements rich with reflection and resolve, President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan and His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, reaffirmed that the country's progress begins with its people, especially its youth and families, whose values, resilience, and dreams continue to shape the nation's journey.

As the nation marks another year since its historic union, the UAE's leadership called on every citizen, especially its youth, to carry forward a legacy defined not only by ambition and innovation, but by the human values that continue to guide the Emirati spirit.

Spirit of the nation's founding remains alive

Speaking directly to "brothers, sisters, sons, and daughters," Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed said the spirit of the nation's founding remains alive in every Emirati family and every young person striving to contribute to the UAE's progress.

"Empowering citizens to actively contribute to shaping the country's future remains a fundamental priority," he said, stressing that national identity, Arabic language, and ethical



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■ Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed celebrates Eid Al Etihad with family members yesterday.

values must guide future generations even as they embrace science and technology.

"A nation without identity has neither a present nor a future," the President said, urging youth to stay rooted even as they lead in fields such as AI, innovation, and scientific research.

He said that the family is the "first school" and "first line of defence" for protecting culture, strengthening society, and

securing the country's demographic future.

Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed highlighted major national shifts including the Year of the Community (2025), Year of the Family (2026), and a renewed focus on strengthening fertility rates and community cohesion as part of a long-term effort to preserve the social fabric on which the UAE was built. He also emphasised the UAE's hu-

manitarian commitments from supporting global peace to easing civilian suffering in conflict zones, describing these efforts as an extension of the nation's identity and values.

Pride, gratitude, and continuity

Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid delivered a message centred on pride, gratitude, and continuity. He said the

founding of the UAE remains "a remarkable journey to fulfil the aspirations of its people," and stressed that the values of the Union must live on through the next generation. "The youth of the UAE are our pride today and the promise of the future," he said, praising their commitment to learning, service, and innovation.

He added: "Celebrating Eid Al Etihad reminds us to uphold

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Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan

our principles, values, and traditions, and pass them on to the next generation. Our achievements are now part of our history, a legacy we continue to build upon."

Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid also reflected on the UAE's global accomplishments, from leading humanitarian aid contributions to pioneering national AI strategies, and said these successes are rooted in strong families, cohesive communities, and a shared sense of purpose.

Both leaders honoured the pioneering generation that built the Union and the families who continue to uphold the values that shaped it. Their message was clear: amid rapid transformation, the UAE's strength remains anchored in people — in the stories carried across generations, the resilience nurtured at home, and the national identity that unites everyone who calls the Emirates home.

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Sharjah Ruler inaugurates Al Estiqlal Square project



SHARJAH
BY LEKSHMY PAVITHRAN
Assistant Online Editor

His Highness Dr Sheikh Sultan Bin Mohammed Al Qasimi, Supreme Council Member and Ruler of Sharjah, inaugurated the Al Estiqlal Square project yesterday morning, following the completion of works that included the construction of the Independence Monument, along with the development of the square and surrounding buildings.

The inauguration coincides with the UAE's 54th Eid Al Etihad celebrations.

Dr Sheikh Sultan unveiled

the commemorative plaque of the 34-metre-high monument at the centre of the square, topped with a seven-pointed star symbolising the seven emirates.

The monument stands as a prominent urban landmark reflecting the site's historical and national significance.

Its four sides display historical information about the UAE's independence. The main plaque notes that on the morning of December 2, 1971, the Rulers of the emirates met and agreed to form a state called the United Arab Emirates after the country gained independence from Britain.

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